

ANATOMY OF A TEA PLANT

With up to five harvests a year, the *Camellia Sinensis* is a highly productive plant. Every part of the plant is used, from the tender spring leaf buds to the mature leaves and small twigs.

The underside of the leaf is covered in fine hairs called "pekoe." This indicates a high grade of tea.

Flower buds are white in color, and develop into seed-producing flowers.

Tender leaf buds are valued for spring green and white teas.

Small white flowers will eventually form tea seeds (see below).

Seed pods hold 1-5 seeds. Sometimes the seeds are pressed to make tea oil.

A stem with two leaves and a leaf bud is at the right stage of growth to be plucked.

More mature leaves are used for making oolong tea.

Leaves are shiny, with serrated edges.

Small twigs are used for Kukicha tea in Japan, and a type of white tea in Malawi.

TEA SEEDS

These are brown, round, and about $\frac{1}{2}$ in (1cm) in diameter, sometimes with a flat side. They have a very hard shell and therefore take 4-6 weeks to germinate. With proper care, the seeds can germinate and grow into adult plants.

